

*Imp In The Garden
and
Other Fairy Tales*

Vaishali Narkar and Sanjeev Khandekar

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www.vaishaliandsanjeev.com

Histograms of an Anxious Present:

Notes on

‘Imp in the Garden and Other Fairy Tales’

1. “We Are All Mutants”

Neither cherub nor hero nor yet angel of love and war, this figure seizes our attention at once: the malformed figure that multiplies itself across the surface of Vaishali Narkar and Sanjeev Khandekar’s mixed media work, ‘Prodigious Births’, part of a suite titled ‘Imp in the Garden and Other Fairy Tales’. Several histories of miscalculation meet in its deficits and asymmetries. What could have been the bearded head of a Roman emperor is rendered tragic instead, by an unfocused gaze. Worse, the head is fitted on a torso that is only superficially similar to the sort of heroic fragment of classical statuary celebrated by Rilke in his address to Apollo. We realise with a tremor that this torso belongs to the history of genetic damage rather than that of iconoclastic vandalism: it is equipped with small, misshapen, flipper-like protuberances, proto-limbs that stand in for arms and legs.

In the skeletal versions of a similar figure, which occur in another of Vaishali and Sanjeev’s works, ‘Monsters and Prodigies’, we puzzle over the peculiar existential limbo that such beings must inhabit - between embryo and biological misprint. They are strongly reminiscent of the freak infants or chimera-like animals preserved in jars by 19th-century biologists, or the deformed child victims of the mercury dumped into Minamata Bay in Japan by irresponsible corporations during the 1950s and 1960s.

The horror of mutancy appears all the more vivid in Vaishali and Sanjeev’s suite of works and indeed, summons forth compassion and terror, because it is articulated through the shimmer of beauty. These images have been constructed through the most exquisitely sumptuous design, patterning and embroidery. Why are we compelled by these visions, how do they hold our gaze hostage? Perhaps this is because they prompt to consciousness an intuitive awareness that we all possess: we all know, in the deliberately Orwellian phrase of the evolutionary development biologist Armand Marie Leroi, that “[w]e are all mutants. But some of us are more mutant than others.”

That observation should explode the generic notion of everyday normality which all of us carry, within ourselves. Like the reassuring background thrum of the tanpura, it allows us to cope with the scintillations and percussions of a demanding life, to average out the peaks and troughs of experience. From the standpoint of such a normality premised on a precarious balance, any departure towards extremity is a life threatening hazard. Therefore, both perfection and eccentricity, the prodigy and the monster are to be held at a distance, since they can plunge us either into fantasia or into nightmare. Vaishali and Sanjeev address these extremes head on in the ‘Imp in the Garden and Other Fairy Tales’. The effect of these works, which produce captivating entanglements between the shimmer of beauty and the horror of mutancy, is rather like that of a Zen koan: we are shocked into a deep awareness of the complexities that underwrite our current historical horizon.

Vaishali and Sanjeev who began work on this project in 2006 have chosen embroidery as their principal medium and they deploy it in various avatars, drawing on the skills of numerous collaborators to structure their images. However, these images are not drawn from the traditional vocabularies to which their artisanal colleagues are habituated. Rather, they emerge from the debates that shape our existence in epic scale but also invisible ways: they allude to the human costs of ecological catastrophe, genetic manipulation, cellular engineering, and molecular warfare.

It is as though the micro-structure of the stitch, the basic unit of embroidery, is being re-fitted to serve the purposes of the microscopic vision and the nano-diagram. As the embroidery builds up, the effect is that of a dense, cumulative palimpsest, seen to advantage in subdued light. As layer is accreted upon layer, we observe how the threads and knots have been wrought and figured into elaborate, low-relief compositions. Look more closely at the plush pile of closely woven threads - the surfaces of cloth seem to become knotted up and transform themselves, before our eyes, into scabbed skin, clotted fungus, thick moss, growing lichen, lacerated wound, ridged bark, and the flowering multi-cellularity of treacherous cancers. We savour the interplay between the smoothness of the medium and the roughness of the images and sensations it conjures up.

Created through the medium of what were once derided as the decorative arts, the works that comprise ‘Imp in the Garden and Other Fairy Tales’ make a powerful statement, both in terms of their formal strategies as well as their conceptual impact. Formally, they stand as energetically contemporary manifestations of a lineage that includes the narrative tapestry, the calligraphic scroll, and the pichhwai. At the conceptual level, they act as histograms of an anxious present.

2. A Teratology for the Times

The eponymous figure who gives his name to this exhibition, 'Imp in the Garden', refers to the chance of mutation that can disrupt the imagined bower of serene predictabilities. The imp carries lightly, as his heredity, the antinomian and adversarial mandate of the serpent in the Garden of Eden. He symbolises recessive genes that spring up without warning, chemical prompts that can destabilise a sequence of hereditary transfer, and unpredictable moments of saltation that spike the settled pace of evolution. The artists also imply that his story is one among a series of 'Fairy Tales' - as we know, fairy tales are a repository of the cultural, social and political complexities that we must negotiate as we develop a mature and productive selfhood. They act as a training ground where we can act out and encounter these complexities in symbolic form, as a form of apprenticeship to experience, a rehearsal for being-with-others.

If the cunning wolf, the murderous bluebeard, the ravenous ogre and the Old Man of the Sea are types that spring from the corpus of the world's fairy tales to occupy the imagination, Vaishali and Sanjeev are equal to the task of generating a teratology for the times: a catalogue of conjoined, disproportionate, incontinent beings, compounded from the scandals of lack and excess, atrophy and hypertrophy. Armand Marie Leroi's study, *Mutants: On Genetic Variety and the Human Body* (2003), has been one of their starting points for this project, as has Sanjeev's long-standing fascination with two exhibitions of photographs, 'Faces' and 'Freaks', presented by the writer Vijay Tendulkar several decades ago.

For Vaishali and Sanjeev, the core question is, how do mutants throw the contested condition of normality into relief? In proposing answers to this inquiry through this suite of works, they elaborate an extended meditation on that museum of afterthoughts, wrong turnings, unexplored alternatives and unmarked comparisons, which stretches in the space between birth and mortality. In the process, as we pass from one work to another in this suite, we find ourselves forming a connection between the figure of the mutant and the various inhabitants of the social, political and cultural peripheries of our public sphere.

In 'Wingless Cupid on Carpet' for instance, we are haunted by the eyes of the wild piebald child that stands partly concealed by vegetation - is this a fugitive who is hiding from the guardians of normality, or a harlequin-skinned spectre preparing to spring at our prized conventions of repressive order and murderous civility? This cupid is an envoy, not of sensuous love, but of visceral hate.

The mutant is another name and another mask for the Stranger, who is feared and reviled because he cannot be understood, and who is provoked into hate. To understand and accept the Stranger is to surrender the pathology of suspicion that serves many of us as an armour against change.

3. Innovating in Research, Design and the Studio

In consonance with this emphasis on mutation, 'Imp in the Garden' is a richly layered project that holds out several bold proposals for a renewal of artistic practice through grafting, interface and mediation through other practices and production systems. I would read this enrichment of the artist's work through the triple optic of research, design and the studio.

At the level of research, it has involved an extensive exploration of material across fields such as genetics, photography, embroidery, and teratology, and across such diverse venues as the archive, the antiquarian collection, the used-clothes warehouse and the internet. The first step, that of choosing the image and structuring it through specific choices of material, has led the artists to such key modes of research as a well regarded showroom for curtains and tapestries on the Juhu Link Road in Mumbai. Another major staging point in their journey was the phalanx of shops that buy and sell old embroidery - whether Parsi kor or pure-silver *jain zari* - near Chor Bazaar, in central Mumbai.

Vaishali and Sanjeev have spent considerable amounts of time in the godowns of cloth merchants, pursuing their quest for patterns, motifs, methods. As a result, 'Imp in the Garden' enshrines a robustly confluent approach; we find, in these works, the silk border of a Banarasi sari, the finely wrought border of a Parsi ghara, and the margins of Kashmiri carpets, all brought together either as referents or as components.

Botany is another area of research for this project. Vaishali and Sanjeev studied the depictions of flora and fauna in Mughal and Rajput paintings, they consulted the records of the Royal Gardens at the Kew Palace, London. Equally central to their research was, of course, medical science. They have resorted to the copious archives of medical abnormality, which expanded to monumental proportions during the late 19th and early 20th centuries, even as eugenics and race theory captured the imagination of many among the imperial elites, and more and more of the colonised world's population was conscripted into the grand machine of capital, squeezed of labour and stigmatised with Otherness.

At the level of design, 'Imp in the Garden and Other Fairy Tales' has been sustained by a meticulous, painstaking and heuristic process of material choice, testing and prototyping media and motifs to identify what would prove viable, durable and, above all, convincing as expressive articulation. Through this iterative strategy, Vaishali and Sanjeev hold the opulence of detail in synchrony with the

formal ambitions of the overall scale of the work. As a result, neither is detail overwhelmed by forbidding scale, nor is scale dissipated by runaway detail. Instead, both work together to generate an event - the coruscating image.

And at the level of the studio, we find that Vaishali and Sanjeev have developed a 'doing-space' that is part research laboratory, part workshop, and part school. They have not simply made use of existing skills, instead even as they have learned from their weaver colleagues, they have engaged in dialogue with them, training them in new languages of image-making, encouraging them towards non-traditional responses to colour, texture and form while addressing their anxieties at having to work with unfamiliar images.

With mutual pedagogy established as the structural principle of the studio, the artists have worked with a changing cast of colleagues, as specialists have come and gone, or because entries and exits are charted along the seasonal cycle of migration to the city and return to the village. The process is labour and time intensive and encodes not only the diverse aesthetic preferences but also the varied temporalities of its contributors. These embroidered images allow for a slow release of emphases and epiphanies.

Through its innovative methodology 'Imp in the Garden and Other Fairy Tales' expands our understanding of the role of research and design in artistic practice, as well as the scope and structure of the hybrid studio. Just as importantly, in the spirit of successive waves of avant-garde activity from the early 20th century onward, 'Imp in the Garden and Other Fairy Tales' poses a vital and refreshing challenge to the economy in which it is situated as a work of art. It makes provocative demands on its viewers with its appetite for formal experimentation. Indeed, it interrupts the cycle of reception and acquisition with an aesthetic challenge, inviting the revulsion of the faint-hearted as much as it does the admiration of those who accept instability and hazard as necessary conditions of viewership.

Ranjit Hoskote

Ranjit Hoskote (b. 1969) is a poet, cultural theorist, and curator, and the author of several books including many acclaimed poetry collections. He has written major monographs on Indian contemporary artists and co-authored a critical history of cultural confluence. Hoskote has curated many important exhibitions in India and abroad,



Title: Prodigious Births

Medium: Embroidery on silk, with acrylic & dyes, artificial zari on silk

Size: 60" X 36"

Year: 2006



Title: A Caprice Of Nature
Medium: Embroidery on silk, with acrylic & dyes, artificial zari on silk
Size: 60"X36"
Year: 2008